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THE 2015 ELECTIONS AND CONFLICT DYNAMICS IN MYANMAR

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The watershed Myanmar 2015 elections are widely regarded as more credible and inclusive than any previous polls in the country, and were largely experienced as peaceful and without disruptions. Despite a mostly quiet election day, the electoral process, however, was not free of conflict. One major cluster of conflicts impacting the electoral process revolved around tensions between ethnic armed groups (EAGs) and the national government's military forces, the Tatmadaw — usually termed 'ethnic conflict' (see Laoutides and Ware, this volume). Another cluster of conflicts concerned the growing anti-Muslim sentiment, with the potential for violent escalation. A third conflict cluster evolved around questions of constitutional justice.[1] This chapter briefly outlines the conceptual framework for elections and conflict, and then proceeds by reviewing the major clusters. The section on elections and the peace process is followed by a discussion of a little understood element of the electoral process, the partial cancellation of elections. The chapter concludes by summarizing some nascent conflict-mitigating measures of the 2015 electoral process and provides an outlook for challenges ahead.